The African Centre for Social and Emotional Learning (AXSEL)

Strategic Brief

Background and Purpose

The African Centre for Social and Emotional Learning (AXSEL) builds on the legacy of the Action for Life Skills and Values in East Africa (ALiVE). ALiVE was launched in 2017 as part of the Regional Education Learning Initiative (RELI) to address a persistent learning crisis in East Africa, where millions of children attended school but failed to achieve meaningful outcomes. Recognizing that literacy and numeracy alone could not capture children's readiness for life, ALiVE focused on the broader capacities youth bring into the classroom: emotions, attitudes, relationships, values, problem-solving, collaboration, and self-awareness. Through participatory research, contextualised assessment tools, and large-scale household and school-based surveys across Kenya, Tanzania, Zanzibar, and Uganda, ALiVE produced the region's first reliable data on adolescents' life skills, shifting conversations from aspiration to evidence-informed action.

To translate this evidence into sustainable practice, the ALiVE Academy (AA) was established as a capacity-building arm, that has by December 2025, trained 1,039 educators, government actors, and practitioners in hybrid, practice-based programs. The Academy delivered targeted streams on assessment frameworks, classroom and household-based assessments, and data analysis, embedding life skills and values into teaching, assessment, and system-level planning. By 2025, ALiVE had reached a strategic inflection point: the initiative had the tools, evidence, and human capital to support Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) at scale, but required a permanent, continental institution to expand its impact.

AXSEL represents this evolution. As the fifth pillar of ALiVE phase III, AXSEL is an African-led, social enterprise arm of ALiVE, established to drive long-term, sustainable change in social-emotional learning (SEL). It supports ministries, universities, teacher training institutes, employers, and civil society to strengthen youth capacities and embed SEL skills across African education systems, helping to realize ALiVE's vision of all children acquiring essential social-emotional competencies.

Main Problem We are Solving

Despite efforts to integrate life skills—such as communication, collaboration, critical thinking, problem-solving, and creativity—and values like love, responsibility, and respect into curricula, less than 10% of adolescents (ages 13–17) in East Africa demonstrate proficiency, with problem-solving as low as 2.7% (RELI, 2022). This gap places adolescents at heightened risk of poor learning outcomes, early pregnancies, early marriages, school dropout, and other adverse consequences. Key drivers include insufficient integration, teaching, and assessment of life skills within schools, compounded by systemic weaknesses in African education systems. These manifest as limited teacher and system capacity to nurture and evaluate SEL, scarce context-adapted frameworks and tools, and a weak shared understanding of SEL and its measurement across classrooms and communities.

AXSEL's mission is to strengthen African education systems by developing African-led, system-facing capacity and practitioner expertise to integrate, nurture, and assess social and emotional learning (SEL) in a sustainable and measurable way, ensuring that youth acquire the skills, resilience, and agency to thrive in rapidly evolving social, technological, and economic contexts while translating policy frameworks into tangible outcomes at scale.

Vision (2040)

By 2040, AXSEL will be Africa's leading centre for Social Emotional Learning (SEL) assessment and accreditation, recognised for tools and credentials rooted in African contexts. It will enable governments, institutions, and employers to measure SEL competencies and certify youth and

practitioners, supporting education, workforce readiness, and youth development across the continent.

Mission

AXSEL strengthens African systems and practitioners to design, deliver, and sustain high-quality SEL by providing standards, credentials, learning pathways, and evidence that are rooted in African realities and built through learning-by-doing.

Core Mission Principles:

- **African-led, African-centred:** Anchored in African expertise and evidence, ensuring relevance, ownership, and lasting impact.
- **System-facing:** work primarily with curriculum, assessment, teacher education, and quality assurance bodies – while opening accessible pathways for teachers, youth workers, and young people themselves.
- **Whole-system spine:** align curriculum, pedagogy, and assessment for SEL, not treating SEL as an add-on.
- **Evidence-based:** Builds on ALiVE's contextualised measurement work and data to establish a robust African knowledge spine on SEL.
- **Practice anchored:** Upholds the ALiVE "learning-by-doing" DNA, with every credential and course linked to real system or classroom projects, ensuring skills are applied, internalised, and drive systemic transformation.
- **Future-ready:** experiment responsibly with AI and technology to scale assessment, feedback, and access while protecting ethics and equity.
- **Ecosystem-strengthening and collaborative:** Serves as the backbone of the VaLi ecosystem, partnering with ALiVE and other stakeholders rather than competing

Strategic Levers/Pathways

AXSEL will advance its mission through four strategic levers: Certifying SEL competence; Integrating SEL into curriculum and pedagogy; Building a credible and agile institution through partnerships; and Securing Sustainable, Mission-aligned Financing. The strategic goals of each lever/pathway is highlighted below;

Strategic Pathway 1: Accreditation & Certification

The strategic goal of the accreditation and certification pillar is to establish AXSEL as the continental reference for certifying competence in Social and Emotional Learning, offering flagship credentials from micro-credentials to co-badged postgraduate programs. AXSEL's flagship program is the AXSEL Certified SEL Systems Specialist (ACSSS), which combines formal learning with supervised, system-based project work. These credentials equip practitioners to integrate SEL across curriculum, assessment, quality assurance, and teacher training systems. Each credential is practice-anchored, grounded in African contexts, and distinguished by hands-on projects, cross-country peer learning, and supervised experience in assessment and measurement, ensuring skills are applied, internalised, and drive systemic transformation. Below are prioritized strategies to deliver this pathway;

- **Pilot and Launch Flagship SEL Certification:** Establish the foundational SEL credential to develop system-facing practitioner expertise and validate the approach through applied pilot programs.
- **Establish Quality Assurance and Governance:** Implement robust governance structures, competency standards, and quality frameworks to ensure credibility, consistency, and integrity of credentials.

- **Scale Credentials and Integrate Innovation:** Expand credential tiers, embed quality assurance processes, and integrate research insights and emerging technologies (e.g., AI) to strengthen relevance and impact across multiple contexts.
- **Build a Continental Credential Hub:** Position AXSEL as a pan-African reference point with a full suite of recognized credentials, micro-credentials, and co-badged awards, ensuring sustainable reach and influence across countries

Strategic Pathway 2: Curriculum & Pedagogy:

The Curriculum and Pedagogy Pathway seeks to deliver dual-training, hybrid, and co-developed programmes integrating SEL into curriculum, pedagogy, and assessment. AXSEL develops and delivers hybrid, co-designed programmes that embed SEL into curriculum, pedagogy, and assessment. By combining centre-based training with real-world classroom and system practice, AXSEL ensures that teachers, school leaders, and trainers can nurture SEL effectively, adapt learning frameworks to local contexts, and implement evidence-based strategies that strengthen student outcomes across diverse education systems. Below are prioritized strategies to deliver this pathway;

- **Develop a Comprehensive SEL Curriculum and Pedagogy Framework:** Establish a coherent, evidence-informed curriculum and instructional model that defines competencies, learning outcomes, and integrated pathways across curriculum, assessment, and classroom practice.
- **Collaborate with System Actors for Co-Creation and Capacity Building:** Partner with ministries, teacher training institutions, and universities to ensure curriculum relevance, co-develop content, and build local facilitation and coaching capacity.
- **Validate and Refine Through Pilots and Evidence Loops:** Use iterative implementation and feedback cycles to test curriculum effectiveness, generate evidence on learner and system impact, and continuously improve pedagogy and delivery.
- **Institutionalize and Scale Across Education Systems:** Embed SEL curriculum and pedagogy into pre-service and in-service teacher training, strengthen partnerships for sustainability, and expand thematic modules and professional learning communities.
- **Position AXSEL as a Continental Leader in SEL Innovation:** Drive thought leadership and innovation at a regional and continental level, integrating emerging technologies, research insights, and next-generation system leadership to advance high-quality, scalable SEL solutions.

Strategic Pathway 3: Governance & Partnerships:

AXSEL builds a credible, agile, and legally anchored institution, forming strategic partnerships with ministries, regional bodies, universities, teacher training institutes, and youth organisations. These collaborations enable AXSEL to influence policy, align system priorities with SEL integration, and create a coordinated continental network that supports sustainable, scalable impact across multiple education ecosystems. Below are prioritized strategies to deliver this pathway;

- **Establish Robust Governance and Oversight:** Put in place a functional governance structure with an active Board, clear policies, and effective oversight mechanisms to guide AXSEL's strategic direction.
- **Build Strong Leadership and Operational Capacity:** Recruit and operationalize a capable leadership team and secretariat, supported by technical and practice panels to drive implementation and quality.
- **Strengthen Strategic Partnerships and Institutional Recognition:** Develop and sustain high-value partnerships with governments, universities, and regional bodies, while positioning AXSEL within policy and strategic education agendas.
- **Define and Transition Toward Long-Term Institutional Sustainability:** Chart a clear pathway toward legal independence, supported by governance reviews and a sustainable financing and resource mobilization strategy.

Strategic Pathway 4: Sustainability & Financing:

The purpose of this strategic pathway is to ensure AXSEL's long-term sustainability by mobilising diversified, mission-aligned resources, including premium credentials, service contracts, and accessible public offerings, securing the financial resilience needed to scale high-quality, system-facing SEL programmes across Africa. Below are prioritized strategies to deliver this pathway;

- **Establish Financial Foundations and Anchor Funding:** Put in place core financial systems, governance structures, cost models, and a clear investment case, while building an initial pipeline of funding to support set-up and early operations.
- **Operationalise Revenue Streams and Early Financing:** Activate initial income streams through flagship programmes and partnerships, secure anchor funders and multi-year grants, and test the viability of early financing mechanisms.
- **Diversify Revenue and Pilot Innovative Financing:** Expand income sources through earned revenue and new products, while designing and testing innovative financing approaches to support scale, access, and sustainability.
- **Achieve Financial Resilience and Sustainable Growth:** Build a balanced and diversified revenue model, strengthen financial reserves, and scale proven financing approaches to support long-term, pan-African sustainability.

Pillar 5: Evidence Sourcing and Application

The Evidence Sourcing and Application pillar anchors AXSEL's work in data, research, and practice. It systematically collects, curates, and translates evidence to inform SEL assessments, credentialing, program design, and system-level decision-making. The pillar will ensure that SEL measurement and tools are grounded in African contexts and real-world practice, strengthening AXSEL's authority as the continent's centre for African-led SEL excellence. The proposed strategies for delivery of the pillar include;

- **Establish a Robust Evidence Architecture:** Build a credible, well-governed, and systematized evidence base by consolidating datasets, strengthening data governance standards, and ensuring secure, ethical, and accessible evidence systems.
- **Make Evidence Actionable:** Translate evidence into practical tools, platforms, and knowledge products that directly inform teaching, assessment, and system-level decision-making.
- **Lead Comparative and Frontier SEL Research:** Position AXSEL as a global reference point by advancing cross-country research, driving innovation (including ethical use of technology), and shaping the future of SEL frameworks and practice.

Proposed Phased Roadmap (2026–2040)- Implementation Matrix attached.

- Phase 1 – Foundation (2026): Institutional set-up, legal registration, flagship credential design, pilot micro-credentials.
- Phase 2 – Early Roll-Out (2027–2028): Formal registration, pilot flagship cohorts, validated dual training, and credentialing systems.
- Phase 3 – Scale & Deepening (2029–2032): Regional expansion, thematic modules (mental health, AI, humanitarian contexts), and a growing cadre of SEL experts.
- Phase 4 – Continental Maturity (2033–2040): Pan-African recognition, ~10,000 SEL-competent practitioners, evidence of measurable youth SEL outcomes linked to peace, social cohesion, and employability.

A Call to Partnership

AXSEL offers a unique opportunity to drive African-led, evidence-based SEL integration across education systems, shaping culturally relevant pedagogy and youth development at scale. Partners can endorse our strategic blueprint, support pilot programming and capacity-building, and champion

AXSEL across policy, funding, and technical networks, helping establish a sustainable, continental centre of excellence that transforms education outcomes and builds future-ready learners across Africa.